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(1986)

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*A dark membrane over the will, holding a man down
Even when the mind has flickered awake;*

D.H. Lawrence, "Men in New Mexico"

1 ROCKETS

Complacencies
of the cafeteria, late coffee and Godiva chocolates,
the octagon of crystal, white fountain splash,
broad arias in pre-noon sun mingle to dissipate

that orb of uncontrolled fusion.
We have these late balcony breakfasts,
and the short waves push the melanomas
down through our bald heads.
Sam, like Oppy, wears a hat:
"Now we're all sons of bitches"

-but Oppy didn't say that.
Still, we are. Even more,
we are rockets, fired at will.
Our work is not ours, and this
is the tension
at breakfast.

2 ALICE

On our first date we met at the golf course.
We walked down Diamond to the under-
pass, turned onto the dirt
road, leading up to the edge of North Mesa,
leading then into the ruins.
The hiking map laid out the no-trespassing zones
Single cross-hatched: "Indian Sacred Land"
Double cross-hatched: "Security Zones"
(There are fines.)

3 TRINITY SIGHTS

The generation behind us saw dawn in the south.
It woke them.
For their memory, we are deformed,
professionally. Renormalized.
Our light has no source, but somehow we are
its subject. It polices us.

I dream best in Alice's room.
I stop breathing, wavering at full exhale,
begin to fly. I'm in some auditorium
but the roof is arbitrarily far.
There is a trick to this kind of flying:
wires cross, skew, at scattered altitudes;
I cannot ascend too quickly.
At extreme altitude, the space evanesces,
an airy latticework of spins...

Transversality, sprays, relay, cloud cover.

I am a superhero, waking quickly
into a scientist's mild-mannered body.
Alice lies next to me, strangely untouched.

4 THE CARE OF THE SELF

A common thread linking these problems is the concept of nonlinear 'self-trapping': that is, a spatially extended excitation modifies the medium in such a way as to 'dig a hole' for itself and become strongly localized.

Brochure, Center for Nonlinear Studies.
Los Alamos National Laboratory, LALP-85-18.

Home is where the mild have the power to harm,
Home and laboratory.

In sunlight, the link to danger
is more rootlike, rhizoid
like the wires bunched on the backplate of SELENE.

How can we work our words?
Fidelity or power, Latin or Navajo, Prolog or Algol?
The one who is always speaking
is like the computer scientist,
slow, Ajax-like, stupid to the light, sound,
and small angels of the quantum.

5 LOST IN SPACE

Look, Alice.
Write $\langle \psi | A \phi \rangle$.
You can move the A to the other side
if you add a dagger: $\langle A^\dagger \psi | \phi \rangle$.
Hilbert space!

Lost in Space.
That was a show in 1966.
In 1966 my babysitter looked just like Penny.
I remember her in a pink and blue
miniskirt, scolding the robot, who was just a man
in a robot costume, with no holes for eyes.

Final season, next-to-last episode. Remember!
Dr. Smith, evil saboteur turned cowardly neurotic,
begins to turn into a lettuce, his roots
going down into the Great Vegetable Planet.
Will and the Robot can't pull him away...

6 THE FIBER BUNDLE

Each of us has a speaker,
a speaker of the self.
It tells us what is going on,
and it tells others.
My sister told me this:

Her husband lost his language
when he was 30. Some fiber bundle
on his brain's left side broke
up, with blood- stroked into
conduction aphasia.
Speech-arc severed, he would say
ma chin ok tzeeq'ana!
This was my sister's most perfect gift.
She decided his thoughts,
granted him an extinct language- Ixil Mayan,
took over his journals,
wrote poems in his name.

It's like that-
It's always the bad scrap that inspires us,
some odd tic in a sentence, some quirk
of logical form triggers the flow.

It's like Lucretius-
the world as some uniform rain,
as we wait for the random swerve,
setting things off, dissipating energy,
building forms.

For money and love,
I take spaces and fasten them together,
using ordinary space as glue.
Fiber bundles.

An algebra tells we how
they overlap and twist into each other.
A thread through the spaces is a field,
swerving, turbulent, meaningful.

And so on, becoming physics.
 $\Phi\upsilon\sigma\iota\varsigma$ is the same as *Natura*
so you would think it was like touching rocks,
not brackets and algebras.
But oh god,

I think of Bruno, his last *Ascent of Man*,
sitting, lecturing on *Hamlet*,
fingers curled into the eye-holes
of his Cro-Magnon girl.

We want to get our fingers into it,
fingering beyond the closure,
fingering through holes too small for minds.

We leave danger, responsibility, and Alice, distal
to the fiber bundle's break.
Here, proximal,
is pink,
and blue.